

PRABHJOT GILL

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

▶ PUNJAB

UNFORCED ERRORS OPEN UP THE GAME

As Mann compounds the 'sins' of his party, the Akalis plan to recapture the angry Sikh devout

FOUR FULL SEASONS LEFT TO GO for its assembly election in 2027, Punjab is already a potboiler full of climactic foreboding. A striking picture on January 15 expressed it perfectly, as chief minister Bhagwant Mann was summoned to the Akal Takht. Usually the effervescent sort, his barefoot walk to the sacred seat, head bowed and humble of aspect, said all that needed to be said.

The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) has time to repent at leisure—and perchance repair. Panthic politics is new turf for it, so it waded, eyes wide open, right into a minefield, each misstep successfully triggering a new detonation. The latest: Mann's claim that the Punjab Police had traced 169 of 328 missing Guru Granth Sahib *saroops* at Rasokhana Shri Nabh Kanwal Raja Sahib in Banga. Instead of pleasing the devout, it outraged them, forcing this awkward retreat. Worse, it was an attempt at expiation for an earlier infraction: days ago, Atishi Marlena's alleged sacrilegious remarks in the Delhi assembly had handed its rivals the perfect weapon to accuse AAP of insensitivity towards the faith. An unforced error that cost game and set.

And match? Wide open, perhaps wider than thought before. So much so that a gloomy laggard, Sukhbir Badal's Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD), now has a window to climb back into the script. Via the scripture, the very area on which perceived weakness had brought it doom in the first place.

PANTHIC VACUUM

The Sikh body politic is the nucleus of Punjab politics—in fact, its controlling stakeholder. But its central alcove had been empty after the SAD was forced to evacuate it in a spectacular fall from grace circa 2017. Ever since, there's